The Anthem

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

How a poem scribbled during one night of bombardment became a nation's song — and what its verses actually say.

A war going badly

The War of 1812 had dragged on for two years — a conflict over British seizure of American sailors, trade blockades, and expansion on the frontier. For much of it, the young United States lost. Then, in August 1814, it got worse: British troops marched into Washington, D.C., and burned the Capitol and the White House, sending President Madison fleeing into the countryside. The nation's capital lay in ashes.

Baltimore was next. It was the third-largest city in the country and a nest of American privateers who had been raiding British shipping — the British press called it a "nest of pirates" and wanted it punished. The city's harbor was guarded by a single star-shaped fort: Fort McHenry. If the fort fell, Baltimore fell. In September 1814, the most powerful navy on earth turned toward it.

Francis Scott Key, on the wrong boat

Key was a well-connected Washington lawyer and an amateur poet — devout, patriotic, and, like many wealthy Marylanders of his day, a slaveholder. (His record on slavery was tangled: he sometimes represented enslaved people seeking freedom in court, yet defended the institution and later helped lead the movement to send free Black Americans to Africa.)

He was not supposed to be anywhere near the battle. Under a flag of truce, Key and American agent John Stuart Skinner had rowed out to the British fleet to negotiate the release of Dr. William Beanes, an elderly physician the British had taken prisoner. Key succeeded — but by then he and Beanes had overheard the British plans to attack Baltimore. So the British held all three men on their own truce ship, behind the fleet, and made them watch.

Francis Scott Key (1779–1843) — portrait, public domain.

Twenty-five hours

For roughly 25 hours, British bomb ships hurled an estimated 1,500 to 1,800 exploding mortar shells and Congreve rockets at the fort — the literal "bombs bursting in air" and "rockets' red glare" Key would later describe. The ships stayed far out in the river, beyond the range of the fort's guns, so the Americans could do little but endure it.

Inside, Major George Armistead's garrison held. A separate British land assault east of the city was thrown back, and the British general, Robert Ross, was killed. As the night wore on and the rain fell, Key had no way to know whether the fort had surrendered — only the flashes of the shells told him the fight went on.

"A View of the Bombardment of Fort McHenry," John Bower, 1814 — aquatint, public domain (Library of Congress).

"By the dawn's early light"

The bombardment stopped near dawn. In the gray light, Key strained to see which flag flew over the fort. Major Armistead had ordered an enormous garrison flag — 30 by 42 feet — made the year before, big enough that the British "would have no difficulty seeing it from a distance." When the sun came up, that giant flag was still there. The fort had not fallen.

That flag was sewn in Baltimore by Mary Pickersgill, a professional flag-maker, working with her daughter, two nieces, and a 13-year-old indentured African American girl named Grace Wisher. The banner that inspired the anthem was stitched, in part, by a Black child who was not free. Moved by the sight, Key began scribbling lines on the back of a letter in his pocket.

The Star-Spangled Banner — the surviving 1814 garrison flag, National Museum of American History (Smithsonian).

"Defence of Fort M'Henry"

Key finished the poem at a Baltimore hotel over the next day. His brother-in-law rushed it to a printer, and within days it was circulating as a broadside — a single printed sheet — under the title "Defence of Fort M'Henry." Newspapers up and down the coast reprinted it. It had four verses, though today Americans almost only ever sing the first.

Read closely, the famous opening isn't a boast — it's a question. "O say does that star-spangled banner yet wave?" Key is asking whether the flag survived the night. The rest of the poem is the answer. You'll close-read the whole thing in the activity below.

"Defence of Fort M'Henry," 1814 — the poem printed as a broadside, with the note "Tune: Anacreon in Heaven." Public domain.

The melody was a drinking song

Key didn't write music — he wrote the poem to fit a tune everyone already knew: "To Anacreon in Heaven," the official song of the Anacreontic Society, a club of gentlemen musicians in London who met to perform music and drink. Its words (by Ralph Tomlinson, melody usually credited to composer John Stafford Smith) celebrate the ancient Greek poet Anacreon, and mix him with wine and love — "the myrtle of Venus with Bacchus's vine."

That origin explains a lot. The tune spans an octave and a half — brutally hard to sing — which is why the anthem trips up singers at ballgames to this day. America's most solemn song is built on a British bar tune about a party.

Recording: "To Anacreon in Heaven" — courtesy University of Virginia Library. Listen for the leaping, hard-to-sing melody, then hear the same tune carry Key's words on the next slides.

"The Anacreontic Song" ("To Anacreon in Heaven") — the London club song whose tune became the anthem. Public domain.

"The Star-Spangled Banner"

Within weeks, a Baltimore music store run by Thomas Carr printed the poem and tune together as sheet music — and gave it the title that stuck: The Star-Spangled Banner. The name came from Key's own words

in the poem. Almost overnight, a handbill about one night's battle became a song Americans could buy, play on a parlor piano, and sing.

Recording: "The Star-Spangled Banner," sung by Margaret Woodrow Wilson, 1915 (Victor). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons). Same tune you just heard — now carrying Key's words.

"The Star Spangled Banner" — first sheet-music edition, Thomas Carr, Baltimore, 1814. Public domain.

Verse three

Key's third verse celebrates the defeat of the enemy — and names "the hireling and slave." To understand the line, you need the context. During the war, the British had offered freedom to enslaved people who escaped to their lines, and formed some of them into a unit called the Colonial Marines. Thousands of enslaved Americans fled to the British for that freedom; some helped fight against their former enslavers, including around the Chesapeake.

Key was a slaveholder. Some historians read the line as a bitter jab at those freedom-seekers — that no escape would save them. Others argue "hireling and slave" is period insult-language aimed broadly at Britain's paid soldiers and forced sailors. The evidence is debated, and honest historians disagree. What isn't debated: American schools sing only verse one, and most students never know verse three exists. Deciding what to do with it is part of your job in the activity.

How it became the anthem

"The Star-Spangled Banner" did not become the national anthem in 1814, or 1815, or for a very long time. It was one patriotic song among many (competing with "Hail, Columbia" and "My Country, 'Tis of Thee"). The U.S. Navy adopted it for ceremonies in 1889; President Wilson ordered it played at military events in 1916; and after a decades-long public campaign — over objections that it was too warlike and too hard to sing — Congress finally made it the official national anthem on March 3, 1931.

That's 117 years after Key wrote it. A national anthem isn't handed down from the founding; it's argued into being. Ours was.

"The Star Spangled Banner," Victor Talking Machine Co. — an early recording, c. 1914. Public domain.

The flag that's left

The actual flag from that morning still exists. Major Armistead's family kept it for decades — and, over the years, snipped pieces off as souvenirs and gifts, even cutting out one whole star. That's why the surviving banner is frayed and smaller than the 30-by-42-foot original. In 1912 the family gave it to the Smithsonian, where it has been painstakingly conserved and now hangs in the National Museum of American History.

It is a strange, honest relic: a giant flag, damaged by the very people who loved it, kept alive on purpose. Like the anthem itself, it survived because Americans decided it should.

NOW DO THE WORK — THE ASSIGNMENT IS BELOW ↓

The Star-Spangled Banner during conservation — the surviving flag is now ragged and smaller than in 1814. Public domain.